lands and taxes, as well as various conditions that are to be kept, such as the maintenance of irrigation channels, tree-planting and the digging of wells. All this was being done by the Cholas as a favour to a distant neighbour, a Buddhist king of Srivijaya in faraway Java.

What these copper plates show is that two committed devotees of Lord Shiva in the persons of the Chola kings Rajaraja and his son Rajendra were happy to extend their patronage – or at the very least, their tolerance – to the local Buddhist community at Nagapattinam. These two Chola rulers felt confident enough to allow their subjects to worship as they pleased, and with good reason.

At the battle of Takkolam fought in 949 the Rashtrakutas had comprehensively thrashed the Cholas almost to the point of eclipse, only for them to bounce back with a vengeance within forty years with the accession to the Chola royal *gadi* or couch of Rajaraja in the year 985. His victories allowed the Cholas to expand northwards and eastwards to the point where they had effective control of an empire that extended all the way round the Bay of Bengal from Lanka to Sumatra. This was very much the work of a father and son team: the father being Rajendra Chola, the same ruler who celebrated his defeat of the Pala king of Bengal and Bihar by naming his new capital Gangaikondacholapuram; the son being his successor and for many years his co-ruler, Rajadhiraja Chola. The conquest of Bengal was just one in a series of military campaigns that began in 1002 with the crushing of his immediate neighbours, continued with the annexation of Lanka and the capture of its king with all his crown jewels in 1017, and culminated in the despatch from Nagapattinam in 1025 of a great armada of ships that led to the conquest of the kingdom of Srivijaya in Sumatra and the Malay peninsula, which won the Cholas ‘a heap of treasures’ and control of the sea-trade in that area. This Chola empire is something